Problem Statement & Context of Use

For this project, I will be conducting a usability audit on the Madison County (Illinois) County Clerk's Office website, specifically the "Elections" section.

This is a government website that many Madison County residents use for several critical democratic functions, including but not limited to: learning if they are registered to vote, registering to vote, signing up to vote by mail, learning where their polling place is, viewing interactive maps of voting districts and polling places, reviewing election results, and more.

The target user demographics for this website include anyone of legal voting age, 18 or older, and could also potentially include people that will soon be old enough to vote, 17 year olds, as they will inherently have to register to vote because it will be their first time doing so. People of all races, religions, creeds, and socioeconomic backgrounds vote, so the main delineation is age. One other thing to consider about target users is that the vast majority will probably already live in Madison County. There may be some users that are planning to move to Madison County in the near future and are seeking out election resources, but largely, if you don't already live in Madison County or plan to soon, you would have no reason to visit this website.

From a quick glance, I have noticed several problems with the website. Just on the home page, there are varying fonts and color schemes, links contained inside of irregular and differently sized photos, low contrast between text and backgrounds, spacing issues, and high cognitive load with many potential things to click on or interact with.

The potential human consequences of interface failure on this website are quite serious. Voting is a sacred and precious right that we have as Americans and if the website provides enough friction or frustration to a user that it prevents them from voting, that is a deep failure by our local government. It is important to thoroughly audit this website so that we can find the flaws and barriers that may prevent people from voting and hopefully make recommendations to eliminate those flaws and barriers to eventually increase democratic participation.

Link: https://www.madisoncountyil.gov/departments/county_clerk/elections/index.php